

Do Majors Make the Player? Academic Fields and Football Performance Among Plymouth State’s 2026 Opponents

MASCAC Football 2026 Data Report

October 5, 2026

Abstract. This report asks which academic majors are associated with the strongest college football players, using real 2026 data from the ten programs Plymouth State (NCAA Division III) has played or will play. We combine official athletics rosters, which publish each player’s declared major at some — but not all — schools, with each program’s results so far. Seven of the ten programs publish majors, yielding 613 players with a declared major out of 757 known rostered players. Business & Management is by far the most common field (42.6%), followed by STEM & Engineering (23.0%, inflated by Massachusetts Maritime Academy) and Criminal Justice & Social Sciences (13.9%); the majors popularly assumed to “produce” athletes — kinesiology/exercise science (4.9%) and sport management (3.6%) — are comparatively rare. Among 43 conference statistical leaders with a published major, business is over-represented (53.5% vs. 42.6%; permutation $p = .089$; Cramér’s $V = .194$): suggestive, but not significant. We find no evidence that any major “produces” better football players; the only strong team-performance signal (STEM-heavy Mass Maritime starting 3–0) is confounded by that institution’s specialized mission. The defensible finding, therefore, is descriptive composition.

Keywords: academic clustering, NCAA Division III, football, majors, MASCAC, ecological fallacy.

1. Introduction

Division III football occupies a distinctive place in American higher education: programs offer no athletic scholarships, and players are admitted as ordinary students who, in principle, choose their field of study freely. That freedom makes the sport an appealing setting for a simple public question — *which majors produce the best football players?* — and an equally appealing target for stereotypes that concentrate on kinesiology, exercise science and sport management. A long line of scholarship has examined “academic clustering,” the tendency of student-athletes on a team to concentrate in a few majors (Fountain and Finley 2011; Paule and Gilson 2011), but it is dominated by Division I revenue sports, where clustering is often tied to eligibility management.

This report assembles an original, reproducible dataset linking declared majors to on-field results for the programs on Plymouth State’s 2026 schedule, and is explicit about what such data can support. We reframe the question into two answerable parts: (1) **composition** — what is the academic-major composition of these rosters, and how well is it documented publicly? and (2) **exploratory association** — among players whose majors are published, is declared major associated with statistical prominence or team success? We deliberately avoid the causal verb “produce,” because the data cannot support it.

2. Data and Methods

2.1 Setting and sample

The sample is the ten programs on Plymouth State’s 2026 schedule: Plymouth State, New England College, Worcester State, Bridgewater State, Dean, Framingham State, Mass Maritime, Westfield State, Fitchburg State, and UMass Dartmouth. Results are as of October 5, 2026.

2.2 Outcomes

Win–loss records, points for and against, and game-level scores were retrieved from the ESPN public team-schedule API and cross-checked against the MASCAC standings (ESPN 2026; Massachusetts State Collegiate Athletic Conference 2026). Ordering matches the official conference table (e.g., Framingham State and Mass Maritime tied at 3–0; Dean 0–4).

2.3 Roster and major data

Player names, positions, class years and declared majors were scraped from each program’s official athletics roster on October 5, 2026. Coverage is uneven and is itself a finding: seven programs publish majors, one publishes them only for a fraction of the roster, and two publish none (**Table 1**). The conference’s All-Academic Team announcements list honored players but not majors, so they could not improve coverage.

2.4 Major coding

Raw major strings (93 distinct values) were collapsed into nine categories using a documented keyword crosswalk: Business & Management; STEM & Engineering; Criminal Justice & Social Sciences; Kinesiology & Sport Science; Sport Management; Health Sciences; Communication & Media; Humanities, Arts & Education; and Undeclared/Other. Joint and dual majors were assigned to their first-listed field. The complete crosswalk and player-level coding are published in `report/data/`.

2.5 “Best player” proxy and analysis

Because individual quality is unavailable for all players (ESPN publishes no Division III box scores), we operationalize “best” as **conference statistical prominence**: the individual leaders published by the MASCAC (top five per statistical category). This yields 62 unique leaders, 43 of whom have a published major. Analyses are descriptive; comparisons of leader versus roster composition use a chi-square statistic, Cramér’s V , and a 20,000-draw permutation test. No causal inference is warranted. Analyses were run in Python; the paper was produced with pandoc and Tectonic.

3. Results

3.1 Coverage

Of 757 known rostered players, 613 (81.0%) have a published major (**Table 1**). Five programs publish majors for their entire roster, Mass Maritime and Dean publish them partially or fully with gaps, and New England College publishes none. The incomplete coverage is the single largest constraint on any conclusion.

Table 1. Data coverage by program.

Program	Rostered	With major	Coverage
Plymouth State	99	99	100.0%
UMass Dartmouth	131	131	100.0%
Worcester State	74	74	100.0%
Framingham State	95	95	100.0%
Fitchburg State	76	76	100.0%
Mass Maritime	125	124	99.2%
Dean	76	14	18.4%
New England College	81	0	0.0%
Bridgewater State	n/p	—	—
Westfield State	n/p	—	—
Total (known)	757	613	81.0%

Note: “n/p” = majors not published on the public roster.

3.2 Composition

Business & Management dominates the sample at 42.6% (**Figure 1A**). STEM & Engineering is second at 23.0%, but this is driven almost entirely by Mass Maritime Academy, where 85 of 141 STEM declarations (and 124 total majors) reside; excluding Mass Maritime, STEM falls to roughly 10%. Criminal Justice & Social Sciences is a distant third at 13.9%. The “athlete pipeline” fields — Kinesiology & Sport Science (4.9%) plus Sport Management (3.6%) — together account for just 8.5% of declared majors. Composition varies sharply by program (**Figure 2**): Mass Maritime is overwhelmingly technical, whereas business and criminal justice dominate the regional state universities.

3.3 Position and major

Majors are not distributed evenly across positions (**Figure 3**). Defensive backs and skill players are the most business-oriented (Secondary 52.7%; Skill 46.2%), whereas offensive and defensive linemen and linebackers are comparatively more likely to be in STEM or criminal justice. Kinesiology is concentrated in skill positions. The overall association is modest ($\chi^2 = 59.10$, $df = 40$, Cramér’s $V = .139$, $n = 612$).

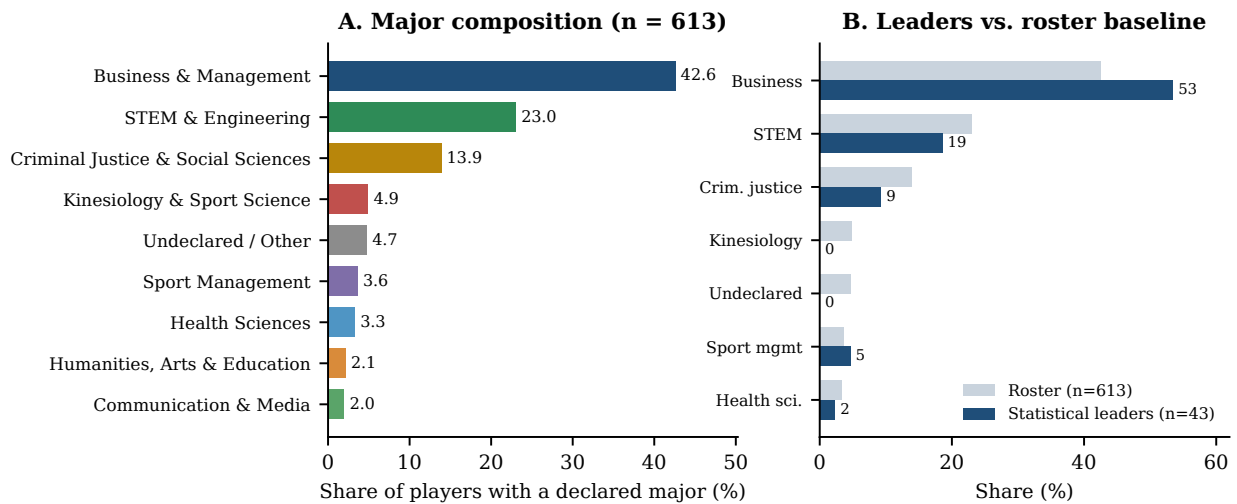


Figure 1: Academic-major composition. (A) Share of the 613 players with a declared major by category. (B) Statistical leaders (n = 43) versus the roster baseline; business is the only category over-represented among leaders.

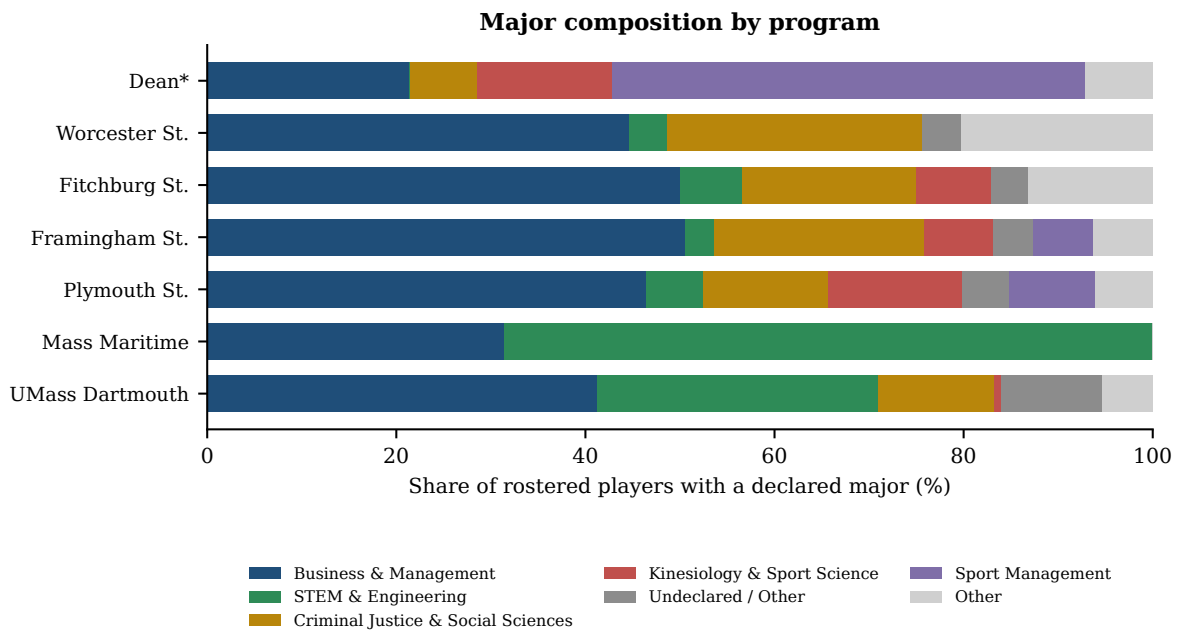


Figure 2: Major composition by program (rostered players with a declared major). Dean (*) publishes majors for only a fraction of its roster.

3.4 Statistical leaders

Among the 43 statistical leaders with a published major, Business & Management is over-represented: 53.5% versus 42.6% on the roster (**Figure 1B**; $\chi^2 = 12.97$, $df = 8$, Cramér's $V = .194$; permutation $p = .089$). Notably, **not one** published leader is in kinesiology/exercise science. The most productive players span fields: the top passer (M. Bakaysa, Worcester State, 1,212 yards and 11 touchdowns) is a Business Administration major; the next (M. Marcucella, Framingham State, 875 yards) studies Accounting; UMass Dartmouth's J. Petrongolo (776 passing yards) is an Engineering major and the conference's leading rusher, M. Wilson (575 yards), studies Communications. Worcester State's leading receiver (L. Williams, 521 yards) is a Public Health major, while the sack leader (T. Taveras, Plymouth State) studies Information Technology. The pattern is suggestive but does not reach conventional significance, and multiple category comparisons inflate Type I error.

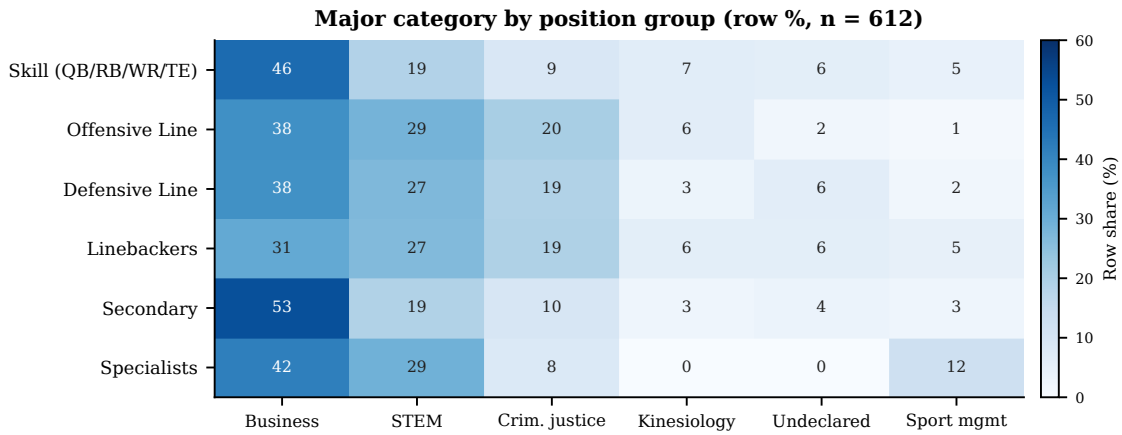


Figure 3: Major category by position group (row percentages; n = 612 players with a declared major).

3.5 Team performance

Team success shows no monotonic relationship with major mix. The two unbeaten programs are opposites: Mass Maritime (3–0, +123 differential) fields an almost entirely STEM/technical roster reflecting its maritime-engineering mission, while Framingham State (3–0) is business-heavy. **Figure 4** plots team win percentage against each program’s share of business and STEM majors; neither relationship is monotonic, and the apparent STEM advantage in success-weighted representation (players declaring STEM have a .73 mean team win percentage and +25.8 mean margin) is produced by a single specialized institution, not by STEM per se.

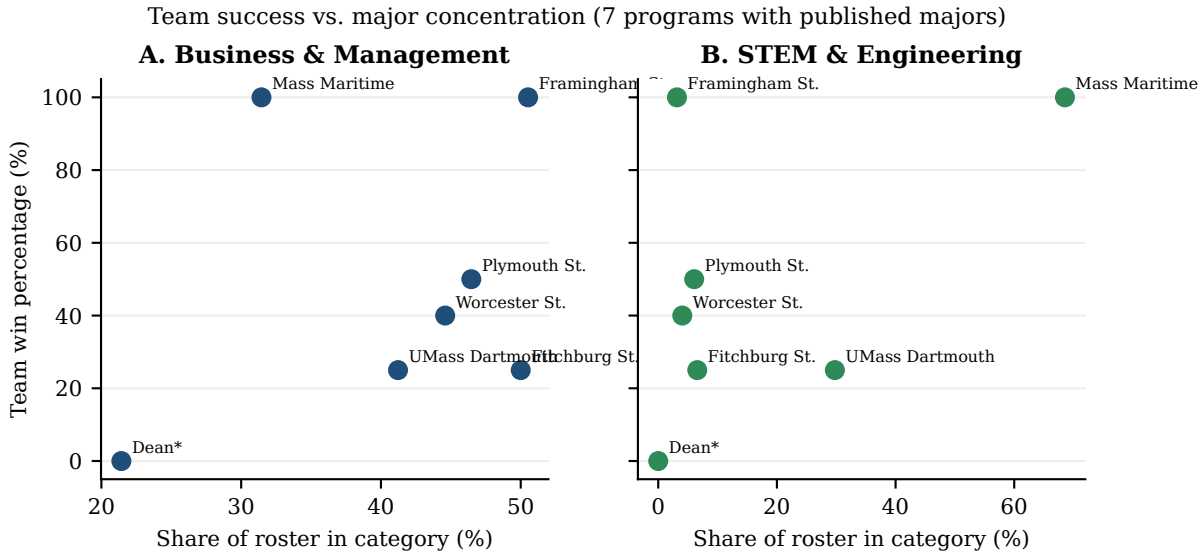


Figure 4: Team win percentage versus the share of a program’s roster in Business & Management (A) and STEM & Engineering (B), for the seven programs that publish majors. Institutional mission, not major, drives the visible pattern.

4. Discussion

Within this sample, **business is the default major for Division III football players**, and the majors popularly associated with athletics are a small minority. This mirrors the academic-clustering literature’s central observation — that rosters concentrate in a few fields — but overturns the assumption about *which* fields: at these Division III programs the cluster is in business, not kinesiology (Fountain and Finley 2011).

The over-representation of business among statistical leaders is the most interesting exploratory result. It may reflect the prominence of quarterbacks, who are both the most heavily publicized players and more likely to choose business;

it may reflect the large baseline share of business; and it may be noise given $n = 43$. We report it as a hypothesis, not a finding. The complete absence of kinesiology majors among published leaders is striking but equally compatible with small numbers.

Crucially, the data provide **no support** for the claim that one major produces better players. The apparent STEM advantage in team performance is an artifact of institutional mission: Mass Maritime is a specialized academy whose entire curriculum is technical, so “STEM” and “Mass Maritime” are nearly the same variable. This is a textbook confounding problem, and it is why the honest answer to the original question is that it cannot be answered with these data.

Two practical implications follow. For advisors, the finding that business rather than sport science dominates DIII rosters is useful context. For the conference, the more actionable issue is data availability: majors are missing for a substantial share of players, which argues for a conference-wide reporting standard.

5. Limitations

1. **Coverage and selection bias.** Majors are published for only seven of ten programs; programs that publish may differ systematically from those that do not.
2. **Ecological fallacy.** Team results are not individual quality; relating team outcomes to major composition risks inferring individual behavior from group data (Robinson 1950), and aggregation can reverse associations (Simpson’s paradox) (Simpson 1951).
3. **Weak quality proxy.** “Best player” is operationalized narrowly as top-five conference statistical prominence, a truncated, non-random selection.
4. **Small n , one season, multiple comparisons.** With 43 leaders in one season, effects are imprecise and exploratory.
5. **Measurement.** Majors are self-reported and inconsistently named, and our category crosswalk involves judgment.

6. Conclusion

Using real 2026 rosters and results from the programs Plymouth State has played and will play, Business & Management is the modal major, “athlete” majors are rare, and statistical leaders skew toward business without reaching significance. We find no evidence that any major produces better football players; the strongest team-performance signal is confounded by institutional mission. The defensible conclusion is descriptive: among the Division III programs on Plymouth State’s schedule, football talent comes from business and general programs far more than from kinesiology or sport management. Answering the causal version of the question would require player-level performance data and complete, standardized major reporting across the conference.

Data and code availability

Derived data are included in this repository under `report/data/` (`players.csv`, `leaders.csv`, `team_results.csv`, `summary.json`). This report is exploratory and not peer reviewed.

References

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